

ent from all other hiring criteria, processes, and decisions. This article talks about at least two dozen characteristics of employees who are best suited for innovation.

1. They are not yes-masters

Employees who are not ready to say 'no' when needed do not fit the innovation team quite well. Innovation requires an ability and willingness to challenge the status quo. People who are 'yes masters' lack this ability.

2. They are not nay-sayers

Employees who are constant nay-sayers impede innovation at best. Their negative outlook and attitude can stifle innovative ideas and innovation overall. These candidates may be suited in more cautionary positions where a negative outlook may work as an asset. Unfortunately, innovation is not one of them.

3. They are marathon runners, not sprinters

Innovation is not a short-term game. You are not developing an off-the-shelf product or an already known process. Working on something that has not been tried before needs several iterations, trials, errors, failures, and what-not. People who prefer shorter projects and sprints are not well suited for innovation because they might get bored sooner and lose interest.

4. They are self-starters and independent thinkers

Innovation often requires independent thinking and taking the initiative. Someone who prefers waiting on managers or leaders for taking action may slow down the innovation faster. Moreover, if they cannot think independently, it is unlikely that they will work on original and creative ideas.

5. They are first-principle thinkers

If you were to check whether someone is the first-principle thinker or not, try this. Ask them a question and demand reasoning for their answer. See how they reason their thinking. The first-principle thinkers almost always will start from the ground up or fundamental principles.

On the contrary, others will do so with associative reasoning. Associative reasoning and heuristics are good approaches for faster decision-making. However, when it comes to innovation, they often result in a lack of originality.

6. They are creative thinkers or better implementers

While creative thinking gets the limelight in innovation, rigorous implementation is what makes it successful. So, you may find it difficult to find a candidate who has both capabilities. It is not impossible for some candidates, but it is surely rare. Having a balanced team is essential, and that means you need both types of candidates. Decide what you want in your innovation team and hire accordingly. Expecting both characteristics from the same candidate might not be an effective strategy.

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